

Redesigning ECON 1740

A proposal: The American Economy — Markets, Institutions, and Modern Prosperity

From: Adam Looney **Re:** An alternative approach to ECON 1740 (American Economic History / American Institutions) **Attachments:** draft syllabus · one-page class sheets (Classes 1–25) · 68-chart slide deck · full teaching notes

The opportunity

ECON 1740 is the **only economics course that satisfies the General Education American Institutions requirement** — one of a handful of courses every Utah undergraduate can use to meet a state-mandated requirement. That makes it the economics department's single best shot at reaching students who would never otherwise take an economics class: a recruiting front door for the major, at scale.

The current course is a fully asynchronous online offering organized around documentary videos and survey history. It serves students, but it doesn't do what this seat in the curriculum could do: **show thousands of non-majors what modern economics actually is** — charts, causal questions, live policy debates — and why they might want more of it.

This memo sketches an alternative. It is a pitch, not a finished product: a design that one instructor could teach, or that several faculty could divide, adapt, and improve. Everything described below already exists in draft — a syllabus, a one-page sheet for each of the 25 classes, full 75-minute teaching notes, and a compiled deck of 68 charts.

The design in one sentence

Every class is built around one killer chart, one economic idea, and one American institution — and the 25 classes tell one continuous story: how America built a growth machine out of institutions, who got access to it, and how it governs capitalism's consequences.

Three design rules make it work:

1. **Charts before theories.** Each lecture is anchored in a single compelling chart — the kind that stops a room. GDP per capita since 1500. Wealth held in enslaved people in 1860. The fading American Dream. Net interest overtaking the defense budget. Students learn to interrogate each one: *What's the comparison? What's the counterfactual? How could this chart mislead me?* That habit — not any list of dates — is what modern economics is.

2. **History paired with the present.** Every historical episode has a live modern twin: railroads and broadband, the 1924 quotas and the 2021 immigration surge, Standard Oil and Big Tech, the Panic of 1907 and the 2023 bank failures. Students never have to ask why the material matters.
3. **One argument, four acts.** The course is a single narrative, not 25 topics. **Part I — The Growth Miracle** (why growth happened, and why in the Anglo-American world). **Part II — Building the American Growth Machine** (markets, invention, firms, wages). **Part III — Mobilizing People and Expanding Opportunity** (who got access: labor, education, immigration, women, race, place, mobility). **Part IV — Governing Capitalism’s Consequences** — framed as the government’s toolkit: rules (antitrust), provision (public goods), insurance and transfers (fiscal policy), stabilization (money and crises), and pricing harms (externalities), bookended by the two open questions, globalization and the AI future.

The framing is unapologetically positive about American institutions and market capitalism — and honest about failures, because the failures (slavery, exclusion, panics, pollution) are precisely where the economics is most instructive. Religious liberty runs through the course as a real economic institution, not a footnote — and Utah examples (the Golden Spike at Promontory Summit, LDS immigration, the Right to Work law, Salt Lake housing costs, Utah fertility falling below replacement, the Opportunity Atlas for Salt Lake County) give the material local punch.

Two deliberate design choices a reader will notice. First, **there is no standalone inequality class**: inequality is taught where the economics lives — wages (10), education (13), mobility (18), taxes and transfers (22) — rather than as a grievance unit, which is both better economics and better classroom politics. Second, **energy** (electrification, oil, shale) is a designed cut, absorbed into the recurring general-purpose-technology thread rather than given its own slot; it is the first class to add if the course ever grows.

The course map

#	Class	The killer chart	The economic idea	The American institution
1	The American Economy in 25 Charts	six-panel dashboard	economics starts with facts	the growth machine (thesis)
2	GDP, Living Standards & Welfare	GDP per capita since 1500	compounding; GDP vs. welfare	the U.S. as the central case
3	The Recipe for Growth	the price of light (Nordhaus)	production function; TFP	schools, universities, capital markets
4	Liberty and the Rules of the	borrowing costs after 1688	self-ownership; credible	common law, religious

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	Game		commitment	toleration
5	The Constitution as an Economic Document	U.S. debt prices, 1786–1794	commitment devices; the common market	the Constitution's economic clauses
6	Why Nations Diverge	the Korean peninsula at night	inclusive vs. extractive institutions	federalism, broad ownership
7	Land, Rails & the National Market	railroad maps 1850–1890	market access; networks	Homestead Act; Commerce Clause
8	The American Invention Machine	patents since 1790; Lost Einsteins	nonrival ideas; spillovers	Patent Clause, universities, federal R&D
9	Factories, Firms & Scale	the falling price of a Model T	scale economies; transaction costs	the corporation; limited liability
10	Productivity & Wages	two centuries of worker pay	marginal product; measurement	free labor + education + labor law
11	Free and Coerced Labor	wealth held in enslaved people	self-ownership; GDP ≠ welfare	the 13th Amendment
12	Labor Markets & Worker Power	unions and top incomes	monopsony; exit vs. voice	NLRA, FLSA, right-to-work
13	Education & Human Capital	the college premium over time	human capital vs. signaling	high-school movement, Morrill Act, GI Bill
14	Immigration & Assimilation	foreign-born share since 1850	complements vs. substitutes	naturalization and quota law
15	Women, Work & Family	female LFP U-curve (Goldin)	household production; opportunity cost	Married Women's Property Acts
16	Race, Migration	Black–white	talent	Reconstruction Amendments,

#	Class	The killer chart	The economic idea	The American institution
17	& Opportunity Cities, Housing & Path Dependence	earnings gap price-to-income ratios	misallocation agglomeration; capitalization	Civil Rights Act zoning and local government
18	The American Dream & Mobility	the fading American Dream (Chetty)	absolute vs. relative mobility	neighborhoods as institutions
19	Trade, Tariffs & Globalization	the China shock map	comparative advantage; adjustment costs	tariff and trade law
20	Market Power & Antitrust	the rise of markups	market power; contestability	Sherman, Clayton, FTC Acts
21	The Useful State	federal spending by category	public goods; free riding	state capacity; federalism
22	Fiscal Capacity	debt to GDP, 1790–2055	incidence; social insurance; r vs. g	Treasury, Social Security, CBO
23	Money, Banking & Crises	two centuries of panics	bank runs; lender of last resort	the Federal Reserve, FDIC
24	Health, Environment & Externalities	pollution falls while GDP rises	externalities; value of statistical life	Clean Air Act, EPA, FDA
25	AI & the Institutions of Progress	fast America, slow America	general-purpose technologies	the whole ecosystem, stress-tested

The American Institutions requirement

Utah Code 53B-16-103 requires instruction in **the history, principles, form of government, and economic system of the United States**. The redesign covers all three prongs, from an economic lens:

Statutory prong	Where it lives
Economic system	Every class — the system of free enterprise <i>is</i> the subject.

Statutory prong	Where it lives
American history	The evidence base of every class: founding-era finance (5, 22), slavery and the Civil War (11), industrialization (7–10), the Great Migration (16), the Depression (23), the postwar boom (10, 13), globalization (19).
Principles & form of government	A dedicated class on the Constitution as an economic document (5) — commerce, contracts, patents, bankruptcy, takings, public credit, no established church — plus the Bill of Rights and religious liberty (4–5), the 13th–15th Amendments (11, 16), federalism (12, 17, 21), the taxing power and Social Security Act (22), the Federal Reserve Act (23), and the Sherman Act (20).

USHE Essential Learning Outcomes are met through chart and data interpretation (sources and evidence), short primary-source readings (Magna Carta, Locke, the First Amendment, the 13th Amendment, Hamilton’s *Report on Public Credit*, the Sherman Act), structured debates with assigned sides (diverse viewpoints), and policy-memo writing assignments.

Why the department wins

- **A recruiting pipeline.** Thousands of gen-ed students see real modern economics — Goldin, Chetty, Autor, the 2024 Nobel — taught through questions they already care about (housing costs, student debt, AI, immigration). The course plants the major explicitly: what economists do, where the tools lead, what to take next.
- **A template, not a personality.** Because every class has the same architecture (chart → idea → institution → debate), any faculty member can pick up a class, swap in their own research, or teach a guest lecture. The one-page class sheets are designed to be handed off.
- **Scales.** One instructor in a large lecture; selected classes suit guest lecturers whose research matches (labor, urban, macro, trade).
- **Low startup cost.** The materials exist: a draft syllabus, 25 one-page class sheets, full 75-minute teaching notes for Classes 2–25, and a compiled Beamer deck with 68 built charts (plus scripts that rebuild them from public data).

What this is not (yet)

This is a pitch, not a turnkey course. Assessment weights, the reading list, and the debate topics are proposals; a handful of charts remain to be built; and the whole design assumes an in-person format that would coexist with (not replace) the current online offering unless the department prefers otherwise. The ask: read the syllabus and a few class sheets, flip through the deck, and tell me whether this is a direction worth building.

Package contents: ECON1740-syllabus (draft syllabus) · ECON1740-class-pages (one page per class, 1–25) · killer-chart slide deck (PDF, 68 charts) · full teaching notes (Classes 2–25).